

“Because of the much lower cost, open source should do very well in this economy.”



Bob Young has played a key role in building Linux into a household name. In 1993, with Mark Ewing, he co-founded Red Hat and was the CEO of the company for several years. After leaving Red Hat, he started a print-on-demand website called Lulu, where content creators can sell their books, comics, movies, or any other content that can be digitised and sold over the Web. Young also owns the Hamilton Tiger-Cats, a Canadian football league franchise that he purchased in 2003. In this interview with LFY, he talks about Lulu.

Q What attracted you to open source and eventually to co-founding Red Hat?

I was unemployed.

Q How did you arrive at a revenue model in open source? Did you have a role model?

Cygnus Solutions was doing reasonably well selling custom engineering services that adapted open source languages and compilers for new processor platforms, mostly for the embedded market.

And there were a few very small Linux competitors, such as Yggdrasil, Turbo Linux and SuSE, who were experimenting with business models at the same time Red Hat was starting up. Only SuSE has survived today as a part of Novell Corporation.

Red Hat's innovation was to

understand that users of proprietary software wanted control over the software they were using, but the suppliers (Sun Microsystems, IBM and Microsoft, among others) were not prepared to give them control. Which gave Red Hat its business opportunity. As [Richard] Stallman would have said, "It was not about price, it was about freedom."

Q Since you mentioned RMS, how do you differentiate between free software and open source software?

I don't! You'll have to ask Richard Stallman and Eric Raymond. They have had many public debates on the fine points of difference. I see open source as simply a better marketing term than 'free' software.